

Understanding and Designing for Family Transitions in Supportive Housing

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Abstract

Families with children represent a growing segment of the U.S. homeless population. To address family homelessness, transitional and permanent supportive housing programs offer housing and wraparound services with the goal of preparing families for independent living and long-term stability. Despite these structured supports, families often face significant challenges during this transitional stage. While prior work in HCI and CSCW highlights how technology can support individuals through major life transitions, the complexities of family transitions remain under-explored. Through a research-practice partnership with a Community Health Center, my dissertation examines the lived experiences of families transitioning out of homelessness and explores the potential for family-centered technologies in housing interventions. Drawing on findings from interviews and design sessions with families, social service providers, and healthcare professionals, my work contributes to an understanding of how families jointly navigate the transition out of homelessness and how to design collaborative, family-centered technologies for major life transitions.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; **Collaborative and social computing**.

Keywords

Family Informatics; Health; Transitions; Housing; Homelessness

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1 Introduction

Families with children comprise a significant and growing share of the population experiencing homelessness in the United States [23]. Homelessness has severe long-term consequences for both parents and children, affecting physical and mental health [11, 21, 25], educational attainment [8], and development [15]. Among the many

challenges families face, the transition out of homelessness into stable housing is particularly complex [9]. Securing housing is only the beginning of the journey to stability, as families must adapt to new environments and routines, build new support systems, and develop independent living skills. Promising approaches to supporting this transition include transitional housing (TH) and permanent supportive housing (PSH), which provide subsidized housing alongside wraparound services such as healthcare, employment support, and life skills training. The overarching goal of TH and PSH is not only to offer shelter, but to prepare individuals and families for long-term stability and independence [16, 24]. While such programs show promise in improving life outcomes and stability [3], the transition out of homelessness remains challenging and under-explored, particularly for families [2, 14]. Prior work suggests that individuals may struggle to adapt to housing programs, which can lead to premature exits and a return to homelessness [7, 19]. Therefore, there is a need for more targeted support within TH and PSH to better prepare residents for a successful transition out of homelessness and toward independent living.

Technology has the potential to enhance existing housing programs by supporting families during this transitional stage, helping them develop independent living skills, establish healthy family routines, and recover from the experience of homelessness. In HCI and CSCW, research has demonstrated the capacity for technology to support major life transitions [13] such as gender transition [12], veteran re-integration [22], and motherhood [4] by facilitating access to resources and social support. In a similar vein, prior work has explored the use of technology to support the transition from pediatric to adult care and different stages of children's illness journeys [18, 26]. While these studies offer valuable insights into the role of technology in facilitating transitions, they mainly focus on individuals' experiences of transition and do not fully capture the complexity of collective transitions involving multiple family members. To address family health and well-being, it is critical to consider the interconnected needs and experiences of family members [10, 20]. During the transition out of homelessness into TH or PSH, parents must oversee and manage the transition while also supporting their children, who must adapt to new living environments, schools, and peer relationships. Designing technology that supports both the individual transitions of family members and their shared interactions within the broader family transition has the potential to strengthen parent-child relationships, stabilize family routines, and promote overall family well-being. Accordingly, my dissertation research investigates the needs of families exiting homelessness and the providers who support them, with the goal of informing the design of collaborative, family-centered technologies that facilitate major life transitions.

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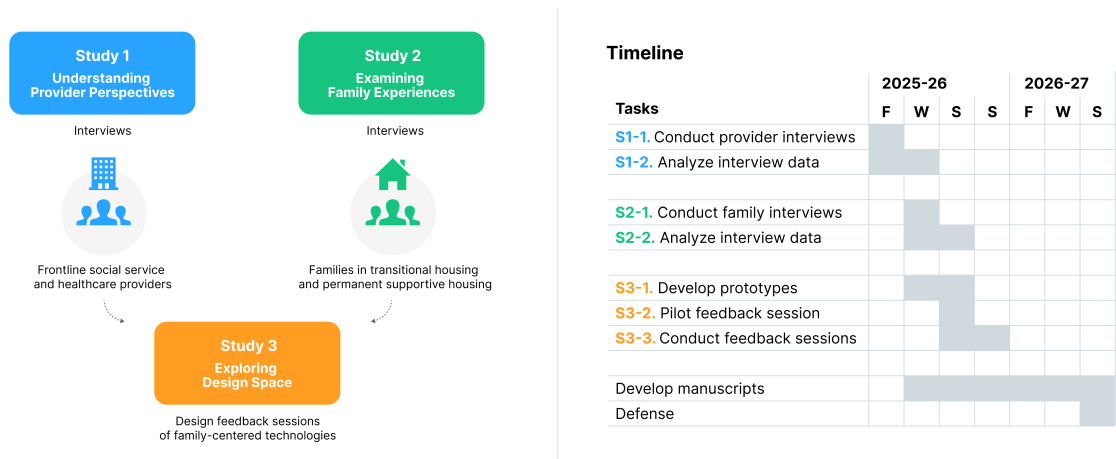


Figure 1: An overview of the research approach and timeline

2 Research Approach

My dissertation is grounded in a research-practice partnership (RPP) with a Community Health Center (CHC) that provides comprehensive healthcare and enabling services to reduce health disparities and improve health outcomes [17]. Located in an agricultural county where 22% of the population lives below the federal poverty line, the CHC serves diverse communities, including migrant workers, low-income and uninsured individuals, and people experiencing homelessness. As part of its services, the CHC operates its own TH and PSH programs for individuals and families with a history of homelessness.

RPPs are long-term collaborations between researchers and practitioners focused on persistent problems of practice and guided by trust, shared decision-making, and a mutual commitment to the production and use of research [6]. To build this foundation, I completed a three-month internship with the CHC, during which I supported program evaluation efforts by examining health outcomes for PSH residents. As part of this work, I shadowed practitioners in the field (e.g., during home visits) to understand the organization’s data practices and infrastructure. In collaboration with a CHC director, we identified a key problem of practice: supporting families exiting homelessness in developing the independent living skills necessary for long-term stability. These skills include physical and mental health management (e.g., medication management), tenancy and basic life skills (e.g., meal preparation), and interpersonal skills (e.g., conflict resolution). Building on the literature and my partnership work, my dissertation investigates the following research questions:

- **RQ1:** How do parents and children adapt individually and together in the transition out of homelessness? What challenges do they face and what strategies do they use?
- **RQ2:** What role does technology play when parents and children undergo this transition? How do healthcare and social service providers use technology to support families in transition?

- **RQ3:** How can we design future technologies to better support families transitioning out of homelessness?

To address these questions, I will engage multiple stakeholders (i.e., parents, children, social service providers, and healthcare professionals) using qualitative methods such as interviews, observations, and design workshops. This approach allows for a comprehensive understanding of the transition process, which will inform the design of family-centered technologies that support families’ diverse needs and experiences in the journey to independent living. My research approach (Figure 1) consists of three main studies, each of which will be conducted in close collaboration with the CHC. At the conclusion of all three studies, I will synthesize and present the findings to inform practice and guide the development of family-centered technologies to support the transition out of homelessness.

2.1 Study 1: Understanding Provider Perspectives and Roles in Family Transitions

In this formative study, I plan to conduct semi-structured interviews with frontline social service and healthcare providers to gain insight into the homeless services infrastructure. Interviews will investigate providers’ views on the challenges faced by families during homelessness and the transition to stable housing, as well as what factors contribute to a successful transition for parents and children. I will also examine how providers support families during this process, with an emphasis on the use of technology to communicate with and coordinate care for families in transition. Using a similar approach, I investigated how school-based practitioners (e.g., school social workers) support housing insecure and foster youth students (forthcoming in CSCW 2025), demonstrating the feasibility of using provider interviews to understand and support families’ needs. I aim to interview 10 social service providers and 5 healthcare professionals from the CHC.

2.2 Study 2: Examining Family Experiences of Housing Transitions

Building on insights from the first study, Study 2 will use interviews to explore families' experiences transitioning out of homelessness and into TH or PSH. Given the sensitivity of the topic, I will incorporate timeline mapping as an elicitation method to help families communicate and reflect on their housing journeys. Timeline mapping exercises have been used to collect rich data in the study of life transitions [1], including individuals' experiences of homelessness [5]. Insights from this study can inform the design of family-centered technologies that are responsive to the distinct phases of housing transitions, similar to how health technologies are tailored to different stages of illness journeys [18]. I aim to recruit 15 families with the support of case managers and community health workers, who have trusted relationships with families.

2.3 Study 3: Exploring the Design Space for Technology to Support Family Transitions

Drawing on findings from Studies 1 and 2, I will develop preliminary design guidelines for family-centered technologies that support the transition out of homelessness. Based on the guidelines, I will create several low-fidelity prototypes that reflect the needs and priorities surfaced through provider and family interviews. As the goal of this study is to explore the design space, prototypes may take various forms, such as tools to help families establish routines, document and reflect on housing journeys, or improve communication between families and providers. The specific focus will be shaped by insights that emerge from the earlier studies. Then, I plan to invite providers and families from the first two studies to participate in design feedback sessions in order to evaluate the prototypes and my interpretation of participants' perspectives. Insights from these sessions will be used to refine the design guidelines, which will inform future technologies that support major life transitions for families.

3 Expected Contributions

My dissertation research contributes to the literature in HCI, CSCW, family informatics, and homelessness. More specifically, the contributions of this work will include:

- An empirical understanding of the needs and experiences of parents, children, and providers in the context of transitional housing and permanent supportive housing.
- An exploration of how families use technology to manage and adapt to housing transitions, as well as how providers use technology to coordinate care for families in transition.
- Design recommendations for collaborative, family-centered technologies that support parents and children in jointly navigating the transition out of homelessness.

Collectively, my dissertation aims to promote the long-term stability and well-being of families with a history of homelessness by providing actionable insights for researchers, practitioners, and policymakers regarding the use of technology in housing interventions.

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